Montagu pointed out to Reading (somewhat obviously), the situation could not be dealt with simply with the issuing of a communiqué: 'There is no doubt that you are confronted by a movement designed and supported with a view to overthrowing your Government and it is of the essence of such a situation that whatever measures are essential for dealing with it must be taken promptly.'[120] Unsurprisingly Reading took offence at the strong terms of this telegram. While the viceroy realised the Home government must be anxious at the situation, 'We must at the same time offer our respectful protest against the implication that so far we have failed to realise the gravity of the present situation as to think that it could be met merely by the issue of a communiqué.'[121]

The debate on how to deal with the non-co-operation movement had effectively become a battle of wills between London and Delhi. Although Montagu had initially supported the viceroy, others in the Home government had never been happy with how the Indian government had chosen to deal with Gandhi, calling several times for the viceroy to simply arrest the Indian leader. In January 1922 Montagu had informed Reading that the British public was apparently becoming more and more perplexed by the fact that Gandhi remained at liberty, despite his seditious activities.[122] However, as the viceroy had tried to explain to the secretary of state, were he to arrest the Indian leader now, 'another will take his place and carry on in Gandhi's name, with the additional stimulus that Gandhi, the saint, is in prison'.[123] The Indian government had a strong belief that if left largely alone, the non-co-operation movement would eventually run its course. In the meantime it refused to make a martyr of its leader.[124] As Reading respectfully pointed out to Montagu, while he understood London's concerns, 'the determination of the situation ought to rest upon my view of the effect in India and not so much in debate at Home'.[125] Indeed, the Indian government had already given Sir George Lloyd, the Governor of Bombay, permission to arrest Gandhi before Montagu's demanding telegram had actually arrived.[126] However, on 8 February, following public outcry at the events in Chauri Chaura, Gandhi called a halt to the non-co-operation movement. The Indian government now decided to gamble and postpone Gandhi's arrest, much to Lloyd's chagrin.[127]